

Cost of Living Testimonies - Aggregated Lived Evidence

These anonymized testimony snapshots show how rising costs affect everyday people across the United States. All statements are aggregated and simplified to protect privacy and to highlight common themes.

CLT1 - Housing

Introduction: Housing costs are the biggest expense for most families. Many people report that rent is rising faster than income.

A renter in Florida says their rent went up by \$400 in one year and they had to move to a smaller apartment.

A family in North Carolina worries about eviction after an investor bought their building and raised the price.

A resident in Texas spends more than half of their income on rent and is afraid to request repairs.

A young worker in Colorado shares a two-bedroom unit with three other people because they cannot afford a place alone.

What this shows: Rising housing costs are forcing people to move, overcrowd, or spend most of their paycheck on rent.

Verification note: These statements are anonymized and represent themes repeated across many submissions.

CLT2 - Healthcare

Introduction: Many people are skipping care or medicine because it costs too much.

A worker in Ohio avoids the doctor because their insurance deductible is too high.

A senior in Arizona takes half doses of medicine to make it last longer.

A parent in Georgia is paying off an emergency room bill slowly even with insurance.

A resident in Pennsylvania avoids the dentist and uses over-the-counter medicine instead.

What this shows: High medical costs cause people to delay care, which can lead to worse health outcomes and debt.

Verification note: These statements are anonymized and represent themes repeated across many submissions.

CLT3 - Food and Groceries

Introduction: Grocery prices have risen and many families are struggling to buy healthy food.

A parent in Michigan skips dinner so their children can eat.

A shopper in Nevada buys mostly canned food and pasta instead of fresh produce.

A resident in New York visits a food bank because their grocery bill keeps rising.

A family in Missouri stopped buying meat to stay on budget.

What this shows: Grocery inflation forces families to reduce portions or switch to cheaper, less healthy foods.

Verification note: These statements are anonymized and represent themes repeated across many submissions.

CLT4 - Childcare

Introduction: Childcare is as expensive as rent or a mortgage for many families.

A mother in Oregon quit her job because daycare cost more than her paycheck.

A family in Virginia spends more on childcare than on their home payment.

A father in Massachusetts has been on a childcare waitlist for a year.

A parent in Illinois pays high after-school costs and is considering working nights.

What this shows: High childcare costs push parents out of the workforce and strain family budgets.

Verification note: These statements are anonymized and represent themes repeated across many submissions.

CLT5 - Work and Income

Introduction: Workers report that wages are not keeping up with rising costs.

A factory worker in Wisconsin has not received a raise in three years.

A teacher in North Carolina works weekends at a restaurant to cover bills.

A driver in California struggles with unpredictable weekly hours.

A resident in Tennessee works long hours but still struggles to stay afloat.

What this shows: Wage stagnation makes it hard for workers to maintain financial stability.

Verification note: These statements are anonymized and represent themes repeated across many submissions.

CLT6 - Debt and Loans

Introduction: More families are relying on loans and credit cards to meet basic needs.

A resident in Texas uses credit cards for groceries and cannot pay down the balance.

A graduate in New York resumed student loan payments and can no longer save.

A worker in Alabama took out a high-interest loan for car repairs.

A shopper in Florida owes money to multiple buy-now-pay-later companies.

What this shows: High interest rates and rising debt make it hard for families to recover financially.

Verification note: These statements are anonymized and represent themes repeated across many submissions.

CLT7 - Education

Introduction: School costs are rising, from supplies to college tuition.

A parent in Georgia had to choose between school supplies and the electric bill.

A college student in Michigan works full-time but still cannot cover rising tuition.

A mother in Texas cannot afford extra school activities for her child.

What this shows: Rising education costs limit opportunities for students and strain families.

Verification note: These statements are anonymized and represent themes repeated across many submissions.

CLT8 - Transportation

Introduction: Transportation is getting more expensive due to gas, insurance, and repairs.

A commuter in California spends most extra money on gas.

A driver in Florida saw a large increase in their insurance bill.

A resident in Ohio relies on buses due to unaffordable car repairs.

A worker in Washington hopes their old car lasts because used cars are too expensive.

What this shows: Transportation costs act like a tax on working people who must commute.

Verification note: These statements are anonymized and represent themes repeated across many submissions.

CLT9 - Stability, Stress, and Mental Load

Introduction: Financial pressure creates constant stress for many households.

A resident in New York has no savings and fears surprise bills.

A father in Kentucky loses sleep worrying about which bills to delay.

A worker in New Jersey feels stuck in survival mode.

A senior in Maine fears winter heating costs.

What this shows: Lack of financial safety nets creates widespread stress across all ages.

Verification note: These statements are anonymized and represent themes repeated across many submissions.